Two categories of inequality

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There are two kinds of inequality, and confusing them is how the comfortable stay comfortable.

The first is **emergent inequality**: unequal outcomes that arise from fair-looking rules, with nobody intending them. Write rules that look perfectly fair, start everyone equal, run the system long enough, and you still get an oligarchy. Nobody cheats; the maths just favours someone. A fair coin-flip game where each player wagers a fraction of the *poorer* one's wealth ends with one person owning everything. Compound interest turns any gap, however small, into an exponential one, while a 50% loss then a 50% gain leaves you down, so the typical fortune drifts toward zero even as the average rises. New links attach to whoever already has the most, so a handful of giant hubs form — links, citations, followers, all power laws. A child who reads slightly better at five gets more books, more praise, and by ten is years ahead. Where your parents lived sets your school, peers, safety and air, none of it chosen; and most jobs come through personal connections, so the network you inherit hires you. Rents rise slowly, then cross a line past which the original residents simply can't stay. The same recession that inconveniences an investor destroys a worker. None of it is designed; all of it compounds.

The second is **adversarial inequality**: unequal outcomes that specific, identifiable people create and defend because they profit from them. Here there are names, budgets, and lawyers — people who benefit from the gap and work to widen it. Landlords and patent trolls collect a cut without producing anything, riding value they didn't make. Industries capture the regulators meant to constrain them and end up writing the rules. Employers suppress wages with non-competes and union-busting. Commons get enclosed; public assets get privatised and rented back. Debt is structured so the borrower can't leave — payday loans, inescapable student debt. Boundaries get drawn so the result is fixed before anyone votes, and the wealthy fund the lobbying that carves the loopholes only they can afford to use. Profit is kept and the harm exported — to poor neighbourhoods, to offshore factories, to the next generation. Over all of it sits manufactured consent: think tanks and owned media funded to insist the arrangement is natural, deserved, inevitable.

In the real world the two braid together. Emergent dynamics open the gap; whoever lands on top then spends the winnings keeping it open. The emergence may be blameless. The maintenance never is.

That distinction is the whole point, because it kills a particular excuse: *this is just what happens when free people get on with their lives, so nobody's to blame and there's not much to be done.* Half true, at best. Yes, much inequality arrives unintended — but a process can be innocent at the start and ugly at the end, and the sane response is to change the process, not to admire how cleverly it works. The other half is plainer once you're looking: rent-seekers, captured regulators, paid-for stories. They aren't accidents. They're load-bearing. They're how the structure stays upright.

The fix has one shape in both halves, even where the targets differ. Where the dynamics push the wrong way, build rules that push back. Where people have built machinery to stop you, confront and dismantle it. Neither is easy; neither is mysterious.

Inequality is a choice. It can be unchosen. The main thing keeping it in place is the belief that it can't be.